Play Store ratings: what's actually wrong, and what to fix first

Recommendation for MoveInSync · Abhijit Kumar · 13 October 2026

4.64★
store rating, India

24,315
written reviews analysed

1,400
AI-labelled, 94% right in a human audit

The answer in four points

1 Not behind the market

#2 of 8 commute apps benchmarked, and 0.011 stars from showing 4.7.

2 What people read is harsh

Written reviews average 3.84★; 9 of the first 10 a visitor sees are 1–2★.

3 It's the app, not the cabs

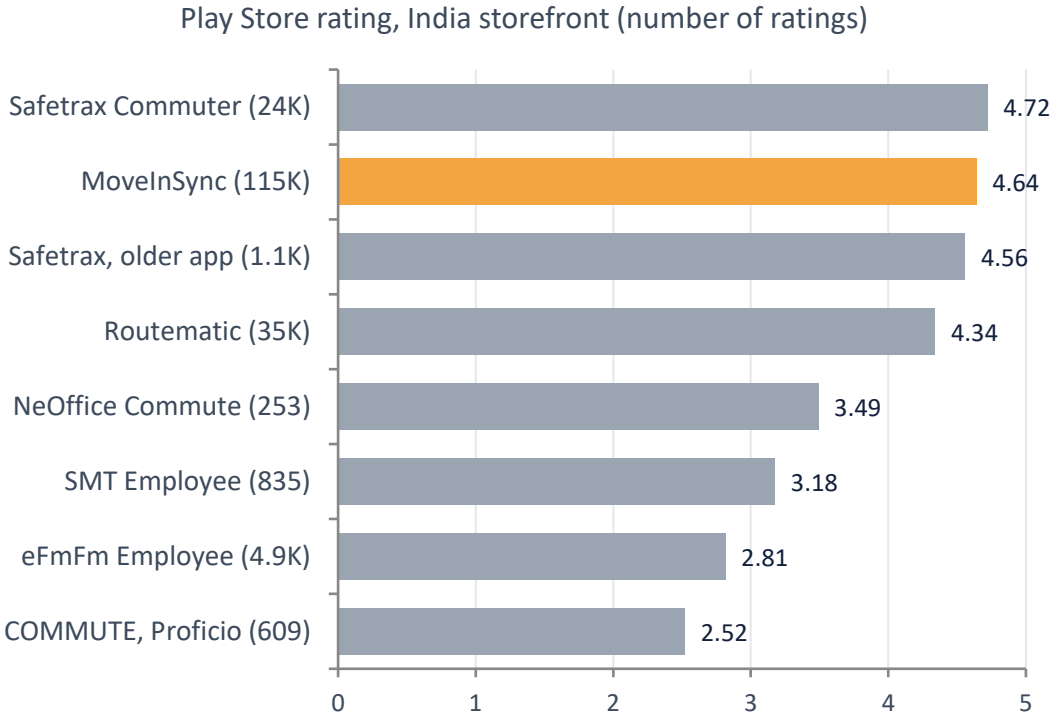
73% of specific complaints are about the app; late or missed cabs, under 5%.

4 It's getting worse now

Stability complaints reached 25% of negative reviews in Q3 2026.

Do first: fix the false install lock-out, gate releases, restart replies, drop the rating wall.

Not behind the market



0.011

stars from showing 4.7 — Play rounds 4.639 down to 4.6

114,880

ratings: nearly 5× Safetrax's, and more than the other seven combined

4.3★

what the same app shows in the US; ratings are per country

The problem is what people read

3.84★

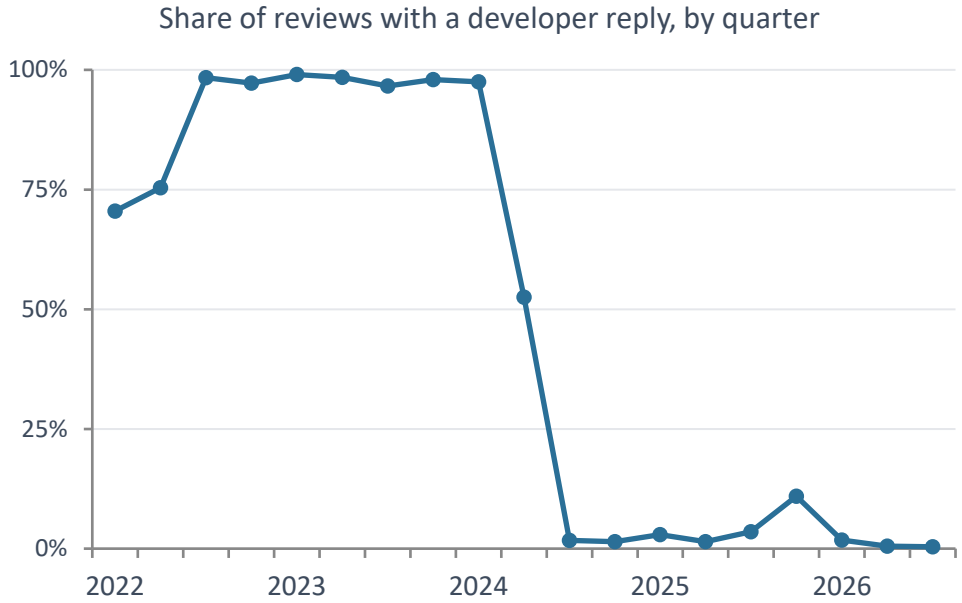
average of written reviews, last 12 months (store shows 4.64)

24%

of those written reviews are 1★

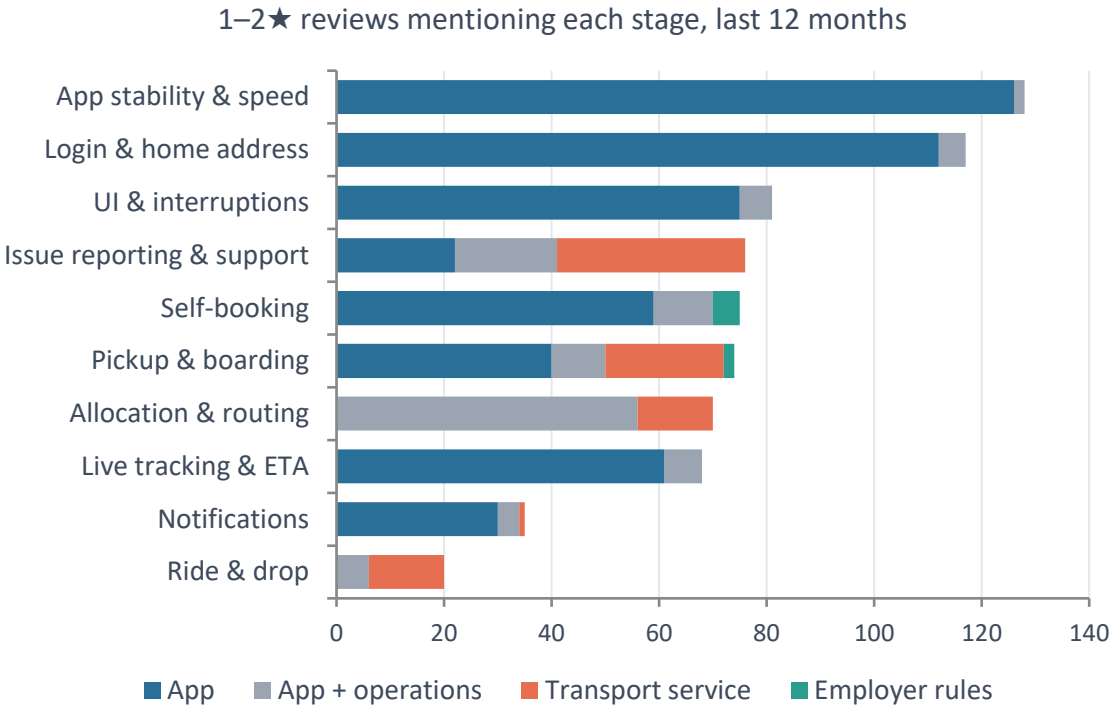
9 of 10

first reviews a visitor sees are 1–2★ — and 9 are unanswered



Replies stopped in mid-2024. Safetrax answers 100%, Routematic 92%.

It's the app, not the cabs



73%

about the app itself

14%

app + operations (mostly routing)

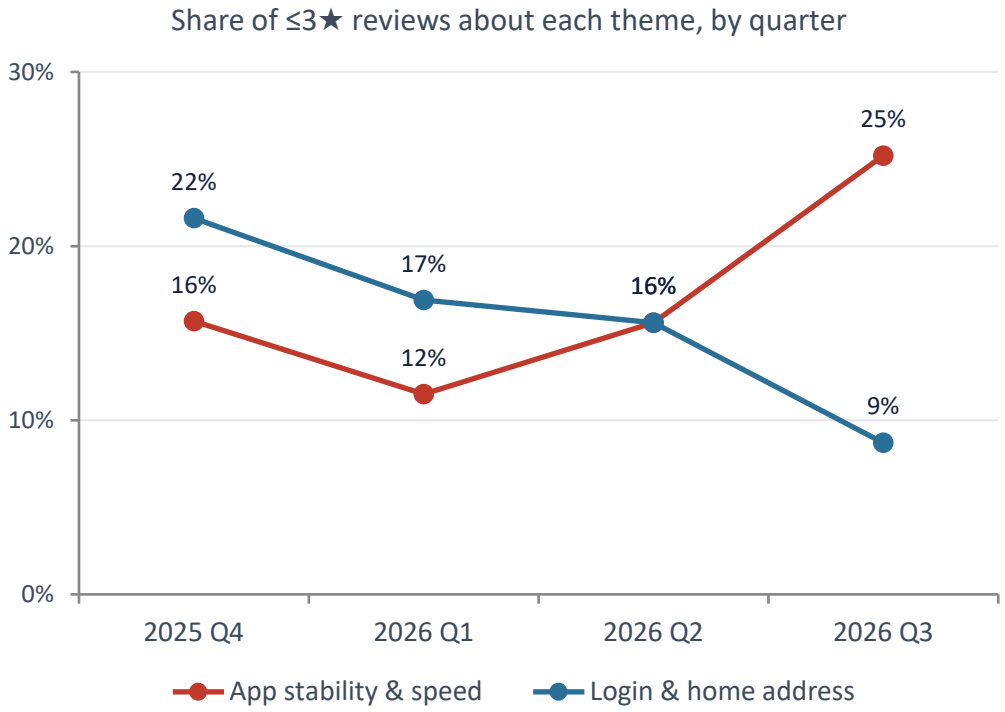
11%

purely the transport service

<5%

late, unassigned or missed cabs

A stability regression is live now



- Stability: 16% → 25% of negative reviews in Q3 2026 (p ≈ 0.01)
- Concentrated in versions 12.16, 12.17 and 12.19 (current)
- False "not installed from Play Store" lock-out: 9 of 12 ever reported came in Jul–Sep 2026
- Same failure in Q4 2023: 43 false "rooted device" blocks
- Login complaints fell 22% → 9%: fixes do show up in reviews

Two things to check on day 1

! The rating prompt

- 20 complaints in 12 months about forced or repeated rating requests
- *"I have to mandatorily give a review of the previous ride before I can access current ride details"*
- 3 reviews say it accepts only 4–5 stars. If it filters who reaches the Play prompt, that is review gating, which Google Play prohibits

! Safety reports

- 23 reviews in 12 months flagged as possible safety risks
- Human audit: 28 of 30 flags genuine; 18 describe a specific incident
- Today they sit unanswered on a public page. Route them to the safety desk within 24 hours

What to do, in order

This week

- Fix the false install lock-out
- Staged rollouts that halt on regressions
- Reply to 1–3★ in 48h (20 drafts ready)
- Skippable trip rating, no star filter
- Safety reports to the safety desk

Next 30 days

- Keep riders signed in
- Reliable OTP, clear login errors
- Unambiguous booking, self-serve address
- Show employer rules when they apply
- Terms once, no blocking pop-ups

Next 90 days

- Honest tracking and ETAs
- In-app complaints with status
- Service complaints to transport desks
- Ask happy riders at the right moment

Expected: halve the top four themes and written reviews rise from 3.84 to ~4.0; 1★ share falls ~5 points.

How we'll know it worked

1. **Daily:** store rating snapshot; new reviews labelled; dashboard refreshed
2. **Weekly:** the answer posted as a GitHub Issue, with a release-watch alert
3. **Always:** a queue for safety reports, contradicting stars and unclear reviews
4. **Cost:** free on keyword rules; about $0.02 a week with Claude Sonnet 5.5

94%

of AI labels right in a human audit; every correction recorded

Dashboard

abhijit-kumar-github.github.io/FDE-Case-Study--MoveInSync

Code, data, method

github.com/Abhijit-Kumar-GitHub/FDE-Case-Study--MoveInSync